

Rhea (Rong) Ren, Ph.D.

UX Researcher | Mixed-Methods | AI Product Research
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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

UX Researcher with 4+ years of experience conducting mixed-methods research on AI-powered products and data-driven systems. Specializes in translating complex user behavior into actionable insights that shape product direction. Demonstrated expertise in AI output evaluation, behavioral analytics, and end-to-end research across EdTech and nonprofit sectors. Experienced working as a sole researcher in fast-paced environments with strong cross-functional collaboration across product, engineering, and design teams.

CORE SKILLS

Research Methods: User Interviews, Usability Testing, Contextual Inquiry, Survey Design, Heuristic Evaluation, Session Replay Analysis, Behavioral Analytics, Preference Testing

AI & Data: AI Output Evaluation, LLM Accuracy Assessment, Behavioral Pattern Analysis, User Segmentation, Statistical Analysis (R, SPSS, Excel), Data Visualization

Strategy & Delivery: Research Roadmapping, Stakeholder Communication, Research Operations, Cross-functional Collaboration, Insight Synthesis & Storytelling

Tools: PostHog, UserTesting, Qualtrics, Figma, Miro, Dovetail, Excel, R, SPSS

WORK EXPERIENCE

Research Associate & UX Researcher | NIET (Educational NonProfit) *Feb 2024 - Present*

- Independently design evaluation plans and research instruments, including surveys, focus groups, and interview protocols, to surface educator needs, pain points, and satisfaction; findings consistently drive 90%+ satisfaction rates across programs and district service partnerships.
- Manage 3 concurrent grant-funded research projects, overseeing evaluation design, data collection, analysis, and stakeholder reporting; present findings to internal leadership, school district partners, and state departments of education to inform service design decisions.
- Produce research outputs including conference presentations (3 proposals accepted annually), research briefs for general audiences, and a forthcoming publication, demonstrating ability to communicate insights across academic and non-specialist contexts.
- Build and maintain data infrastructure across 7 states, including trackers and process documentation, to standardize multi-state datasets and improve cross-team research workflows.

Product UX Researcher | Step Up Tutoring (EdTech) *Oct 2025 - Jun 2026*

- Serve as the sole researcher embedded on an AI-powered EdTech product; own the full research lifecycle from roadmap planning through synthesis and stakeholder delivery across two AI tools - Session Briefing and Tutor SideKick.
- Lead two sequential mixed-methods research programs (Oct–Dec 2025 and Jan 2026–present), spanning usability testing, contextual observation, user interviews, surveys, and session replay analysis; Phase 1 insights established the research foundation and shaped pilot testing direction.
- Triangulate 6+ data sources in Phase 2, including 5 user interviews, PostHog session replays, usage audits across 43 tutors, usage surveys, informal feedback, and panel sessions, to develop a tutor segmentation framework (Power, Elective, Low-usage users) that informed product prioritization.
- Collaborate with AI engineers to evaluate model outputs by reviewing and annotating AI-generated transcripts; feedback directly informs the team's model selection decision.
- Lead quality oversight of third-party vendor research (surveys, interviews, focus groups); identify

methodological gaps and revise instruments to align outputs with product goals, improving insight quality and actionability.

- Deliver rapid research cycles aligned to MVP development; ~70% of recommendations adopted, improving UI clarity, refining user flows, and enabling customized problem set generation.

UX Research Consultant | Freelance - AI & Travel Tech Clients

Oct 2024 - Oct 2025

- Advised early-stage AI startups on research strategy; refined ambiguous product questions into structured research plans that guided product direction for teams without in-house research.
- Conducted ongoing behavioral analysis through session replay reviews, identifying 2–3 key usability issues daily with actionable recommendations grounded in UX heuristics.
- Collaborated with AI engineers to evaluate AI-generated output quality; developed an issue taxonomy to classify accuracy, hallucination, and consistency failures — improving model reliability through iterative feedback.

UX Researcher | Hack for LA (CivicTech)

December 2022 - October 2024

- Conducted user interviews and usability testing to identify Neighborhood Council members' needs and pain points; insights challenged existing designs and drove changes to key features (calendar, search, map), resolving critical usability issues and supporting on-time product launch.
- Defined research roadmap and documented end-to-end research processes, establishing systematic, user-centered practices and a foundation for future research.
- Initiated and led a partnership with the UserTesting platform, improving recruitment efficiency and participant quality.

UX Research Coordinator | Google (Via AnswerLab)

Jan 2023 - Feb 2024

- Managed high-volume participant recruitment across multiple concurrent studies, consistently meeting tight timelines for enterprise clients.
- Refined participant screeners using research principles to improve targeting of qualified users, reducing recruitment time by ~10%.

UX Research Intern | Minority Programmers Association (Tech Nonprofit)

Jul 2022 - Oct 2022

- Designed end-to-end UX research plan as sole researcher; conducted user interviews and competitive analysis to identify NFT marketplace user needs, resolving critical usability issues and supporting a successful product launch.

Researcher | Arizona State University

August 2017 - May 2022

- Led mixed-methods research on learner behavior and cognitive processes; produced 4 publications and 8 conference presentations with direct implications for learning design and education technology.
- Applied research expertise to two end-to-end UX studies, designed wireframes based on user needs, improving navigation efficiency and overall experience.

EDUCATION

Google UX Design Certificate | Coursera & Google

January 2023

Ph.D., Linguistics & Applied Linguistics | Arizona State University

May 2022

- Specialized in second language acquisition, linguistic cognition, and social linguistics, with training in qualitative and quantitative research methods, statistical analysis, and user behavior research.

M.A., TESOL | California State University East Bay

September 2016

B.A., Italian Language & Literature | Beijing International Studies University

June 2014